

Question 53 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Analyse why a training program may receive positive participant reactions but still fail to improve job performance.

Introduction

This is the gap between Kirkpatrick level 1 (reaction) and levels 3–4 (behaviour and results). Participants may honestly enjoy the programme — good food, charming trainer, beautiful venue, easy days away from work — and still work exactly as before on Monday. Analysis must look inside the programme, at the original need, and at the workplace. Do not write only ‘they were happy’.

Detailed points

- 1. Entertainment is not learning.** A motivational speaker and a hill-station venue raise reaction. If skill was not practised, level 2 never happened. Job performance cannot improve from quotes in a notebook. Analysis: the programme optimised the wrong level.
- 2. Learning too easy or too theoretical.** Content that does not stretch, or that never leaves the slide, leaves people happy and still incompetent. They liked it because it did not demand uncomfortable practice.
- 3. Wrong need — TNA was missing.** The performance problem was a tool, a process, an impossible target, or a pay issue. Training cannot improve job performance then, however pleasant. Notes: training is not the answer to all problems. Analysis starts at Stage 1 failure.
- 4. Hostile or empty transfer climate.** The boss says ‘forget the classroom, we have targets’. Peers mock the new method. The official SOP is not the real SOP. Behaviour cannot change. Reaction was about the classroom; performance lives in the department.
- 5. No opportunity to use the skill.** The software is not installed, or the task comes once in six months. Skill decays. Reaction was real; performance chance never came.
- 6. Conflicting appraisal and rewards.** Taught quality; paid only for speed. People follow pay. Analysis: organisational systems beat training. Job performance is a system outcome.
- 7. No follow-up, coaching or IDP.** One event, no refreshers, no supervisor observation. Learning decays. Positive reaction is about a memory of a good two days, not about a changed habit.
- 8. Analytical conclusion for the examiner.** Reaction is a weak predictor of job performance because enjoyment, learning, transfer conditions and organisational systems are different things. HRD must design for levels 2–4 and for climate, not for applause. A programme can fail at any step after a successful level 1.

Conclusion. *Positive reactions with no performance gain usually mean the programme was pleasant but diagnostically wrong, theoretically thin, or unsupported at work. Analyse classroom, TNA and workplace. Do not confuse smile sheets with HRD effectiveness.*